

Egg-laying mammals

Order Monotremata

Short-beaked echidna

Tachyglossus aculeatus

- ↔ 12–18 in (30–45 cm)
- 📍 Australia (including Tasmania), New Guinea
- ⊗ Common

Bristling with long, thick defensive spines, the short-nosed echidna is a low-slung, solitary insect-eater that feeds mainly on ants and termites. It hunts by day and night, locating its prey among the leaf litter with its snout and scooping it up with its long, sticky tongue. It is the most widespread of the monotremes: a group of five mammal species found in Australasia.



Other species

- Duck-billed platypus *Ornithorhynchus anatinus* » p336
- Eastern long-beaked echidna *Zaglossus bartoni* » p315

Marsupials

Orders Didelphimorphia/Peramelemorphia/Dasyuromorphia/Diprotodontia/Notoryctemorphia/Microbiotheria/Paucituberculata

Virginia opossum

Didelphis virginiana

- ↔ 13–20 in (33–50 cm)
- 📍 W., C., and E. US, Mexico, Central America
- ⊗ Common

This cat-sized marsupial is the biggest of the American opossums, and the one species found in North America north of Mexico. It is still expanding

its range in the US, thanks to its ability to thrive in urban habitats. It often nests in outbuildings and can eat virtually anything, ranging from insects and fruit to kitchen scraps. It is famous for “playing possum,” or feigning death when threatened.



hairless, partly prehensile tail

Water opossum

Chironectes minimus

- ↔ 10–16 in (26–40 cm)
- 📍 S. Mexico to C. South America
- ⊗ Common

The slender, long-legged water opossum, or yapok, is the only marsupial adapted for hunting in water. Active by night, it uses its long, webbed hindfeet to swim in pursuit of fish, frogs, and freshwater crustaceans, seizing them with its handlike forefeet.

Eastern quoll

Dasyurus viverrinus

- ↔ 11–18 in (28–45 cm)
- 📍 Tasmania
- ⊗ Near threatened

The six species of quolls are carnivorous marsupials closely related to the Tasmanian devil. The catlike eastern quoll is one of the smallest. Once widespread in southeastern Australia, it now survives only in Tasmania, where it hunts by night for small mammals and also eats some plant material and scavenges from carcasses.

Eastern barred bandicoot

Perameles gunnii

- ↔ 11–14 in (27–35 cm)
- 📍 SE. Australia, Tasmania
- ⊗ Near threatened

Named for the bars on its rump, the eastern barred bandicoot is an omnivorous marsupial that uses its sensitive nose to probe the soil for insects, worms, and seeds at night. By day, it retreats to its nest. It has been almost wiped out on the Australian mainland by foxes but still thrives in fox-free Tasmania.

Common cuscus

Phalanger orientalis

- ↔ 15–19 in (38–48 cm)
- 📍 New Guinea, Solomon Islands
- ⊗ Locally common

Native to the densely forested island of New Guinea, this monkeylike marsupial has strong, grasping fingers and toes and a prehensile tail for clinging to branches. It feeds at night, climbing carefully in search of leaves and fruit. Its color is very variable; some island races are black, while others are almost white.

Numbat

Myrmecobius fasciatus

- ↔ 8–11 in (20–28 cm)
- 📍 SW. Australia
- ⊗ Endangered

Sleek and bushy-tailed, with a pattern of white stripes around its red-brown body, this solitary, day-active marsupial is specialized for eating termites. Using its large-clawed forefeet, it rips their nests open and licks them up with its tongue. It is remarkable for having 52 teeth—more than

any other land mammal—but they are very small. Predation by introduced red foxes has made it extremely rare.

pattern of bands unique on each individual



elongated, pointed snout

Honey possum

Tarsipes rostratus

- ↔ 3–4 in (6.5–9 cm)
- 📍 SW. Australia
- ⊗ Locally common

This mouselike marsupial feeds on pollen and nectar, which it gathers from flowers with its bristle-tipped tongue. This diet is unusual for a mammal, because it relies on flowers being available all year, but—unlike birds and insects—the possum cannot fly to cover a wide foraging area. An excellent climber, it uses its sharp-clawed grasping feet and long prehensile tail to grip twigs and stems.